

Slides 1.11: Label Detective

Lesson 1.11, two days. Day 1: eleven slides. Day 2: twelve slides. Build the deck from this outline. Student-facing text reads at grade 6 to 7.

Day 1: Reading the evidence

Slide 1: Do now

- Look at the package on your table. Do not turn it over.
- Is this a healthy food? Yes or no, and one reason.
- Two minutes. Notes: Hands up for yes, hands up for no. Then: “Everything you used to decide came from the front. The front is an ad. Turn it over.”

Slide 2: The front is an ad. The back is the evidence.

- A label detective reads the back first.
- The back has a box the government makes every company fill in the same way.
- It is called Nutrition Facts.
- Same order, same words, every package. Once you can read one, you can read all of them. Image: a cereal box front with bright colors and claims next to its plain black and white Nutrition Facts panel.

Slide 3: The label, top to bottom

- Servings per container: how many servings are in the whole package.
- Serving size: the amount all the numbers describe. The government sets it, not the company.
- Calories: big and bold on purpose.
- Then the nutrients, then percent daily value down the right side. Image: a full Nutrition Facts label, large, with letters A through G next to the parts the handout asks for. Notes: Students label the diagram on the handout as you go. Serving size first, always.

Slide 4: Get less, get more

- Get LESS of these: saturated fat, sodium, added sugars.
- Get MORE of these: dietary fiber, vitamin D, calcium, iron, potassium.
- Added sugars is new (2020). It separates the sugar in fruit or milk from the sugar the company put in.
- Total sugars minus added sugars is the sugar that was already there. Image: the label with the “get less” lines circled in one color and the “get more” lines in another.

Slide 5: Percent daily value

- % DV means: how much of a whole day’s worth one serving gives you.
- Based on a 2,000 calorie day.
- It is NOT the percent of the food. It is the percent of your day.
- Sodium 9% DV means one serving uses up 9% of your sodium for the whole day. Notes: This is the misconception to kill today. Say “percent of your day” every time.

Slide 6: The 5 and 20 rule

- 5% DV or less is LOW.
- 20% DV or more is HIGH.

- Low is good for the get less list. High is good for the get more list.
- Try it: sodium ____% DV on our label. Low, in between, or high? Fiber ____%? Image: a number line from 0 to 100 with 5 and 20 marked. Notes: Fill in from the poster label. Two examples out loud, then the students do them on the handout.

Slide 7: The servings trap

- The label describes ONE serving.
- This bag has ____ servings. [*Sal: your poster label.*]
- Eat the bag, multiply everything by ____.
- Calories: ____ x ____ = _____. Sodium: ____ x ____ = ____ mg. Notes: Do sodium out loud. Students do calories on the handout.

Slide 8: The Label Scavenger Hunt

- Five packages at your station. Serving size first, then everything else.
- Part 1: fill one row per package on the table.
- Part 2: answer the six hunt questions. Every answer has a package name AND a number.
- “It looks unhealthy” is not evidence. A number is.
- Fifteen minutes. Notes: Clipboard checklist: reads serving size before calories; gives a number as evidence; found the 20% or more item correctly.

Slide 9: Rotate (optional)

- At seven minutes, teams move one station to the right.
- Take your handout. Leave the packages.
- Finish the table with the new packages. Notes: Use this slide only if you want every team to see all fifteen packages. Skip it if the room is tight.

Slide 10: Share

- One question per team. Read the answer and the evidence.
- Class: was the evidence a number?
- The class “most sodium per serving” and “most added sugars” go on the board and stay up until tomorrow. Notes: Leave the two numbers on the board for the Day 2 do now.

Slide 11: Exit card

- 3 parts of a Nutrition Facts label and what each one tells you.
- 2 numbers from a package you read today, with the package name.
- 1 question you still have about labels.
- Three volunteers read one line. Notes: Sort into “got it” and “needs more.”

Day 2: Spot the trick

Slide 12: Do now

- A cereal box says “Made with whole grain.”
- Does that mean it is healthy? Yes, no, or it depends.
- What would you need to see to be sure?
- One minute. Notes: Most say “it depends.” “Good. Today you find out what it depends on, and then you catch a company in the act.”

Slide 13: Trick 1, the serving size game

- A 20 ounce bottle. The label says 2.5 servings.
- Who drinks 40% of a bottle and puts it back?
- The numbers look small because the serving is small.
- Catch it with: servings per container. Then multiply. Image: a 20 ounce soda bottle with “2.5 servings” circled on its label.

Slide 14: Trick 2, “natural”

- The FDA has never formally defined “natural” for most foods.
- So it can go on almost anything. It does not mean healthy, organic, or low in sugar.
- Catch it with: the ingredient list. What is actually in it? Image: three very different packages (chips, a juice drink, candy) all with the word “natural” on the front. Notes: FDA’s page “Use of the Term Natural on Food Labeling” says the agency has a longstanding policy but no formal definition. *[Sal: check for a 2025 or 2026 update.]*

Slide 15: Trick 3, true but beside the point

- “Fat free” on candy. Candy never had fat. Look at added sugars.
- “Made with real fruit.” How much? Where is fruit on the ingredient list?
- “Multigrain” means more than one grain. It does not mean whole grain. Look for “whole” as the first word of the first ingredient.
- Catch it with: the line the claim is not talking about. Image: a gummy snack package with “made with real fruit” on the front and an ingredient list starting with corn syrup.

Slide 16: Trick 4, the health halo

- A green package. A leaf. The word “wellness” or “fit” or “smart.”
- None of those is a fact.
- Your brain reads the color before it reads the label. Companies know that.
- Catch it with: ignore the front. Read the back. Image: two identical labels, one on a bright green package with a leaf and one on a plain package.

Slide 17: Trick 5, three kinds of “less sugar”

- “No sugar added”: nothing was put in, but the food may still be full of natural sugar. 100% juice is the classic case.
- “Sugar free”: less than half a gram per serving.

- “Reduced sugar”: at least 25% less than the regular version. Which can still be a lot.
- Catch it with: total sugars AND added sugars. Notes: Definitions from FDA labeling rules. The fix for all five tricks is the same: turn it over and find the line.

Slide 18: Comparison 1, the juice aisle

- Product A: 100% orange juice. Product B: an orange drink.
- Both say “excellent source of vitamin C.”
- Fill the compare table. Circle the better choice. Name the trick on the front.
- Whole container: if you drank all of B, how many grams of added sugars? Image: two cartons side by side, labels on the handout. Notes: B is 10% juice; the vitamin C is added as ascorbic acid. $8 \text{ servings} \times 28 \text{ g} = 224 \text{ g}$ added sugars in the bottle, about 4.5 days’ worth.

Slide 19: Comparison 2, the chip aisle

- Product C: veggie straws. “Made with real vegetables. 30% less fat.”
- Product D: potato chips. “Made with real potatoes.”
- Which wins on calories? Fat? Sodium? Fiber? Protein? Vitamins?
- Is either one a health food? Notes: C wins calories and fat; D wins sodium, fiber, protein, and vitamins. The vegetable in C is powder, sixth on the list, with no vitamin A or C to show for it. “Neither is a health food” is the best answer.

Slide 20: The ad

- SunBurst Fruit Bites. “Made with REAL fruit. Fat free. Excellent source of vitamin C. The healthy snack for active kids.”
- Here is the back of the box. [Show the label and the ingredient list from the handout.]
- Write a four-sentence critique: the claim, then three pieces of evidence from the label or ingredients that the claim hides.
- Frame: “The ad says , **but the label shows** .” Image: the ad as described on the handout: a smiling kid on a soccer field holding a pouch, strawberries and oranges across the package. Notes: Model one sentence: “The ad says ‘made with real fruit,’ but the first ingredient is corn syrup.” Ten minutes.

Slide 21: One apple, for comparison

- A medium apple: 95 calories, 4 g fiber, 0 g added sugars, 0 mg sodium.
- One pouch of Fruit Bites: 90 calories, 0 g fiber, 11 g added sugars.
- Same calories. Not the same food.
- Grade 8 stretch: design an honest label for a snack that could truthfully say “made with real fruit.” Image: a whole apple next to a small gummy pouch.

Slide 22: Share

- Three critiques read aloud.
- Class: which piece of evidence was the strongest?

- Would the company let this critique run as a commercial? Why not? Notes: Keep the best three critiques; they become the review slide before the quiz.

Slide 23: Exit ticket

- One product from today.
- The trick on its front.
- The one label line that catches it.
- One sentence. Three volunteers read. Notes: The “needs more” pile decides which trick gets a review slide at the start of Lesson 1.12. Optional homework: bring an empty package from home whose front makes a claim.